



Samurai weapons and armour
A group of samurai warriors march in a procession during the Jidai Matsuri Festival of Ages in Kyoto, Japan *(right)*. A *katana,* the *tsuka* (handle) of which is clearly visible, lies among a collection of samurai clothing *(far right)*.

AN HONOURABLE DEATH

The samurai's distinctive attitude to death was an essential part of the search for a heroic but aesthetically refined mode of existence. According to existing accounts of the Gempei Wars – which hover between legend and history – the Japanese tradition of *seppuku* (ritual suicide) was invented by the veteran warrior Minamoto Yorimasa in 1180. Defeated by the Taira at the battle of Uji, Yorimasa took refuge in a nearby temple.

There he wrote an elegant poem on the back of a fan before calmly slitting his abdomen with a dagger. The belly cut, or *hara-kiri*, became the accepted form of suicide for any samurai facing defeat or dishonour, although other modes of death are recorded. At the end of the Gempei Wars, the Taira committed suicide *en masse* by drowning. In a later period, one samurai, Miura Yoshimoto, took this ritual to the extremes of self-decapitation. Of course the Japanese had no monopoly of the practice of suicide as an honourable death for the defeated – to fall on your sword was considered a noble act, for instance, for losing generals in Ancient Rome. But the tradition of the samurai was notable for its extreme emphasis upon making a good death rather than achieving military success.



Yoshitsune and Benkei
The young Minamoto Yoshitsune fighting against the priest Benkei in the 12th century is depicted in this ivory *okimono* (large ornamental carving).

The semi-ritualized character of samurai warfare was possible to sustain only because the samurai almost exclusively fought one another. When the Mongol ruler of China, Kublai Khan, mounted seaborne expeditions to Japan in 1274 and 1281, the samurai were initially wrong-footed by an enemy who ignored invitations to single combat – partly because it was not Mongol custom, and partly because they did not understand the Japanese language. The samurai nonetheless successfully resisted the Mongols, with a great deal of help from a typhoon, the *kamikaze* (divine wind). Japanese forces did not fight a foreign enemy again until their unsuccessful invasion of Korea in the 1590s, but by then samurai warfare had undergone a radical transformation through the means of social change and imported technology.

In the 14th century major advances were made in the development of the sword – soon to become the samurai's principal weapon. A blacksmith called Masamune Okazaki is credited with producing a dual structure of soft and hard steel that provided much improved cutting power and endurance for swordsmen. Masamune's technique resulted in Japanese swords (*katana*) being recognized as some of the most potent hand weapons of preindustrial East Asia. Many swords made using this technique were exported across the East China Sea, a few making their way as far as India. Before coming into the possession of samurai, new sword blades were tested by cutting through the bodies of corpses or condemned criminals. Test results were often recorded on the *nakago* (the metal piece attaching the sword blade to the handle).

In the Sengoku period, beginning in the second half of the 15th century, general disorder reigned in Japan. As the old noble clans declined, many samurai emerged from the lower classes and carved out careers for themselves through their fighting prowess. Samurai with no master to claim their allegiance, known as *ronin*, roamed the country in search of military employment.

THE DAIMYO WARS

Self-proclaimed samurai leaders, the *daimyo* or warlords, attracted a following of fighting men and established themselves in control of areas of the country. Wars between *daimyo* forces tore Japan apart for 150 years. The samurai who fought in these conflicts rarely aspired to the refinement of their predecessors. They were professional soldiers occupying a place in substantial armies. Skill with the two-handed sword, not the bow, was now the mark of a great warrior. Samurai swordsmen were accompanied by large bodies of peasant foot soldiers, the *ashigaru*, to provide them with a degree of disciplined support in battle.

In the second half of the 16th and early 17th centuries, a string of major battles and sieges were contested as *daimyo* fought one another for control of Japan. Although Japanese chroniclers often dwelt upon individual combat between named samurai that apparently took place in the midst of these encounters, battles were clearly in fact decided by a combination of forces used in a tactically sophisticated manner. At Nagashino in 1575, the great general Oda Nobunaga deployed 3,000 *ashigaru* armed with muskets.



Wakazashi
The *wakazashi,* shown here with accompanying scabbard, was a sidearm often used by the samurai to perform *seppuku* (ritual suicide).